Conflict resolution

Definition

According to Featherstone and Kelly (2007[1]), "conflict resolution is concerned with understanding the causes and dynamics of conflict and applying this understanding in processes for peacemaking and peacebuilding" (p. 263). In other words, conflict resolution involves understanding and acknowledging that a conflict exists, recognizing that it can be resolved, and working together in a tacit or explicit way to reach the resolution (Bercovitch, Jackson and Jackson, 2009[2]). This requires the abilities to negotiate, mediate, and collaboratively solve problems (Bar-Tal and Rosen, 2009[3]).

Relevance for 2030

Conflict resolution has relevance for 2030, given the need to manage and negotiate individual, interpersonal and/or intergroup conflicts in day-to-day living. With the rise of nationalist movements on one hand and globalization on the other, there is a growing need for peace-seeking values, perspectives and knowledge generated by conflict resolution in the practice of democracy and justice for the mutual benefit of communities (Anastasiou, 2008[4]). Development of conflict resolution skills in students in such a scenario becomes especially critical.

In order to build caring communities and constructive relationships, "education for conflict resolution, models and teaches a variety of processes, practices and skills that help address individual, interpersonal and institutional conflicts in a culturally meaningful way" (Association for Conflict Resolution, 2002, as cited in (Jones, 2004[5])). These include an understanding of the conflict, the principles of conflict resolution as well as the social, emotional, and cognitive processes and skills related to constructive conflict resolution (Lane-Garon, Yergat and Kralowec, 2012[6]). Research shows that students embrace integrative thinking (the ability to make connections and synthesize information for meaningful learning), as they learn to resolve conflicts constructively both within the school and outside (Heydenberk, 2000[7]).

Links to the Framework

- Creating new value

Well-managed conflicts make people feel more united and prepared to contribute to their groups and organizations (Tjosvold, 1997[8]). They serve as an important catalyst for learning, development, and innovation. Constructively resolving conflicts through collaboration and problem-solving is necessary for innovation, as innovation itself is an inherently disruptive process that can lead to increased tensions (Lawson, 2004[9]; Tushman and Nadler, 1986[10]).

- Reconciling tensions and dilemmas

Reconciling tensions and dilemmas requires proactively evaluating and understanding the perspectives of others (Gehlbach, 2004[11]), showing empathy, exercising self-regulation, and solving problems (Sandy, 2014[12]; Selman, 2007[13]). In their study on effects of a peer mediation program on school violence at an elementary school, Schellenberg, Parks-Savage and Rehfuss (2007[14]) found that the presence of peer mediators, who demonstrated increased knowledge and application of positive conflict resolution through the program, resulted in a significant reduction in out-of-school suspensions, including both physical and verbal conflicts over a long term period (up to 5 years after the implementation of the peer mediation program).

- Taking responsibility

Research on peer mediation in schools shows that by having peers who help students resolve interpersonal problems, students develop an internal locus of control and assume responsibility as they learn to understand the impact of their actions and accept differences (Ibarrola-García and Iriarte, 2014[15]; Noaks and Noaks, 2009[16]).

Impact

Academic outcomes

- Conflict resolution improves classroom and school climate, which in turn can improve learning (Heydenberk, Heydenberk and Tzenova, 2006[17]; Jones and Sanford, 2003[18]).

Social and emotional outcomes

- Conflict resolution skills can reduce bullying and violent behaviour in schools and increase pro-social behaviours (Heydenberk, Heydenberk and Tzenova, 2006[17]; Schellenberg, Parks-Savage and Rehfuss, 2007[14]).
- Conflict resolution skills learned in the classroom lay the foundation both for interpersonal collaboration and productive relationships; they also facilitate the establishment of a cultural norm of peaceful management of disputes (Chaux et al., 2017[19]).

Interrelatedness

Conflict resolution is closely related to

- **Collaboration**: Collaboration encourages open discussion and cooperation among members to move towards a common solution. During this process, there are often differences in viewpoints and members of groups will seek information, clarify, and/or change their viewpoints depending on the strength of the arguments made. This negotiation of conflicting viewpoints is an important element of a collaborative task (Child and Shaw, 2019[20]). Furthermore, the social skills of a group, including their ability to constructively resolve problems enhances collaboration (Johnson and Johnson, 2009[21])
- **Open mind-set**: An open mind-set is one that is receptive to new ideas without pre-conceived notions of values or judgements (Chan et al., 2018[22]). Findings from a study with adults showed that the ability to be open-minded and to understand their partner's perspectives were important social competencies for a mutually focused conflict resolution style that is based on collaboration (O'Connell, Corcoran and Mallinckrodt, 2000[23]).
- **Perspective taking and cognitive flexibility**: The cognitive process of perspective taking not only facilitates information exchange but also supports a deeper understanding of the ideas put forth by

the group and an integration of different perspectives (Hoever et al., 2012[24]). Studies with adolescents have found that competent perspective takers are less likely to use aggression as a way to solve conflicts (Diazgranados, Selman and Dionne, 2016[25]) and are able to distinguish between superior and inferior conflict resolution strategies (Gehlbach, 2004[26]). According to Carnevale (2014[27]), conflict narrows our vision of thought and possibilities. In such a situation, flexible thinking allows us to understand and assimilate more complex sources of information and to be creative.

- **Problem solving**: An integrated-thinking environment associated with effective conflict-resolution emphasizes problem-solving skills. In a study with students in nursing schools in Turkey, students who were enrolled in a problem-based learning curriculum that focused on the students' abilities to work together, identify problems and generate solutions had better interpersonal conflict-resolution skills compared to students who were enrolled in the general curriculum (Seren and Ustun, 2008[28]).
- **Respect**: Education for conflict resolution demands a change from fear and violence to respect and safety, while fostering collective well-being (Opotow, Gerson and Woodside, 2005[29]). Johnson and Johnson (2010[30]) articulate the importance of mutuality based on shared civic values in resolving conflicts and maintaining peace. These values include respect for others and their viewpoints, behaving with integrity, caring for the other parties, compassion when other members are in need, equality, and appreciation of diversity (Johnson and Johnson, 2010[30]).
- **Responsibility**: Opportunities for conflict resolution education provide students with the capacity to take responsibility for their own behaviour and beyond that, for their group and their community. Bickmore (2001[31]) provides a rich analysis of schools that encourage students to take responsibility and share authority through, for instance, asking for inputs in creating codes of conduct or by choosing student peer mediators.
- **Self-awareness**: Self -awareness is thought to be important in conflict resolution. In their study of 108 teams, Jordan and Troth (2009), found a link between the ability to understand and deal with one's emotions as positively correlated to collaborative conflict resolution styles of teams and this was linked to better team performance in problem-solving tasks.

Conflict resolution is also related to

- **Creativity**: Creativity enables individuals and groups to find alternative solutions to their desired goals in the face of conflicts. Organizations where conflicts are resolved constructively tend to be more creative and responsive to clients, report better performance, and benefit from improved decision making because different ideas and opinions can be expressed and resolved openly (Jordan and Troth, 2009[32]).
- **Critical thinking skills**: Critical thinking skills involve analysis and evaluation about the best judgement possible with the available evidence (Snyder and Snyder, 2008[33]). Dialogue, debate and games help students develop insights into the formation and patterns of conflict (Yoshimura, 2017[34]; Wade, 2016[35]). These skills are necessary to support a fair and sustainable solution in a conflict.
- **Empathy**: Empathy has been identified as one the most important social and emotional skill related to positive conflict resolution. In their study with 6th graders, Sakgal, Turnuklu and Totan (2012[36]) found that compared to the control group[1], students who had undergone the peace education program, which included activities that focused on prevention of student violence and resolution of conflict using peaceful methods, had higher empathy scores. Through socialization and interaction

[1] Control group in a scientific study refers to the group that does not receive the treatment or intervention and is used as a comparison to measure the results of the other (experimental) group.

with adults who serve as role models, children can learn to be empathic, and understand how their actions affect others (Sandy, 2014[12]; Schonert-Reichl, 2013[37]).Empathy is also an important skill in improving intergroup relations. For instance, in their review of the role of empathy in intergroup relations Stephen and Finlay (1999) identified the mediational role of empathy in positively changing attitudes and behaviours of people through for instance, arousing feelings of injustice which can counteract prejudice.

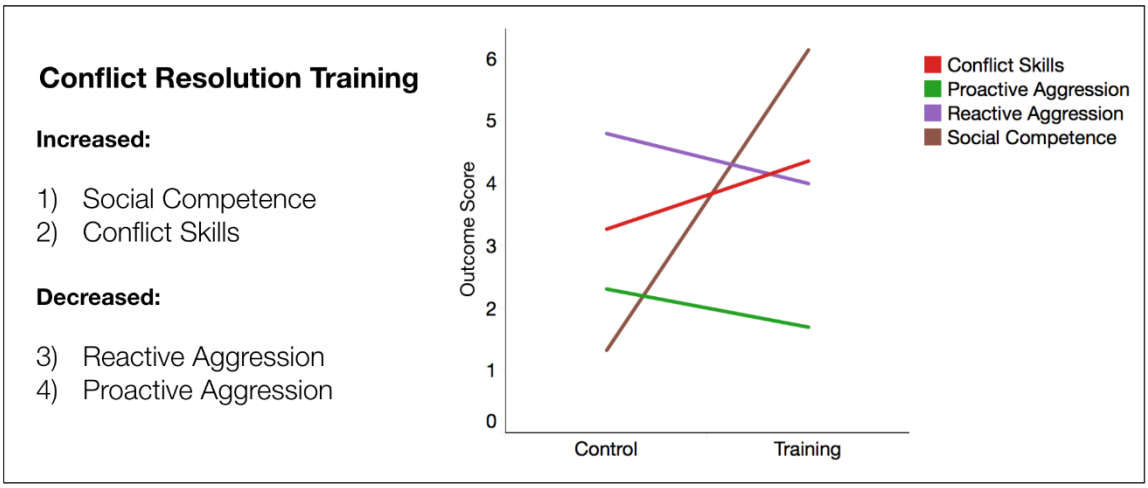
- **Global mind-set**: Research in the international business literature has emphasized two important dimensions of global mindset. The first dimension is cultural diversity which requires reconciling differences between the global and local, and the second dimension is the strategic complexity that managers have to deal with as a result of the demands and challenges of working across borders (Chan et al., 2018[22]; Levy et al., 2007[38]). Both dimensions require capacities to manage uncertainty, balance conflicting demands and resolve emerging tensions.
- **Integrity**: Skills for conflict resolution empowers learners to create friendships and develop caring communities through building trust. Integrity increases trust of all parties in conflict resolution (Kälvemarka et al., 2004[39]). In their study with fourth and fifth-grade students in Philadelphia, Heydenberk, Heydenberk, & Bailey, (2003[40]) found that conflict resolution training had positive effects on students' moral reasoning (i.e. Higher order thinking processes such as the abilities to reason, to empathize and to understand perspectives of others) among students.
- **Justice**: Resolving conflicts requires an awareness about the social conditions in which equity, justice and respect for human rights are maximized. This requires understanding and acknowledging the conflicts and using collaborative ways to think about and re-shape the prevailing status quo (Opotow, Gerson and Woodside, 2005[29]). In order to avoid power imbalances, everyone must have a voice in the conflict resolution process (Hofheimer, Bettman and Moore, 1994[41]).In their analysis of education for peace, Zembylas and Bekerman (2013[42]) stress the importance of identifying own assumptions concerning power relations and social justice and encourage engaging in critical awareness to identify the contextual obstacles which stand in the way of a peaceful culture.
- **Mindfulness**: Mindfulness-based programs can lead to increased well-being and social and emotional competence (Jennings et al., 2011[43]; Schonert-Reichl and Lawlor, 2010[44]). Particularly in the face of stressors, conflicts and dilemmas, practicing mindfulness (for e.g., focused breathing) can lead to feeling calmer, relaxed and having an enhanced experience of well-being. Students in the MindUP mindfulness program, for instance, reported increased mindful awareness and attention of themselves and their surroundings (Maloney et al., 2016[45]).
- **Reflective thinking**: Reflective thinking enables a deep understanding of issues and helps develop a connection between ideas and/or experiences, including ones which might otherwise be ignored (Bar-Tal and Rosen, 2009). In reflecting critically, people question their assumptions and the way this influences their judgements, expectations and behaviours. This allows them to fully understand the conflicts and the point of view of all parties involved (Bagshaw, Lepp and Zorn, 2007[46]).
- **Resilience/Stress resistance**: The ability to deal with dilemmas and daily stressors requires problem-solving coping strategies which allow you to communicate about the situation and work towards finding a solution. (Dumont and Provost, 1999[47]). Without the skills for resolving conflicts, there is likely to be rise in feelings of detachment from others, resulting in increased stress. Downey (2008[48]) in her synthesis of the educational resilience literature, identified conflict resolution as a key life skill that needs to be developed among students, particularly those who are at-risk.

Malleability

According to Coleman et al. (2014[27]), role play, modelling, or rehearsal are effective in teaching children non-violent techniques for handling interpersonal conflicts. Yoo, Matsumoto, and LeRoux (2006[49]) indicate that psychological processes such as emotion recognition and regulation are key in solving cross-cultural conflict.

Akgun and Araz (2014[50]) conducted an intervention study with more than 300 students in a Turkish Elementary school. The conflict resolution training focused on empathy, anger management, social problem solving, and cooperative conflict resolution skills. The results were compared to a control group and indicate that the training indeed increased students' constructive conflict resolution skills and decreased their aggression levels. The results are illustrated in Figure 1 below. The conflict resolution intervention showed the strongest positive effect on social competence (represented by the brown line in the figure). This finding is not surprising since much of the training involved improving empathy and social information processing. The training also had a positive impact on conflict resolution skills (red line) and decreased reactive (purple line) and proactive (green line) aggression. Taken together, Akgun and Araz (2014[50]) found that approximately 14 hours of conflict resolution training (over a 10-week period) was sufficient to improve the students' social competence, conflict resolution skills, and reduce aggression.

Figure 1. Effects of conflict resolution training



Note: Conflict resolution training and its effects on conflict resolution skills, social competence, proactive aggression, and reactive aggression
Source: Figure adapted from Akgun and Araz (2014[50]).

Many research-affiliated centres around the world provide trainings in conflict resolution. Examples include The Centre for Dispute Resolution at Missouri State University, the Center for Negotiation and Conflict Resolution at Rudgers University, Centre for Conflict Resolution, University of Cape Town, or the Martin Daniel Gould Center for Conflict Resolution at Stanford University.

Programs that teach conflict resolution

Lions Quest (https://www.lions-quest.org/) is a K12 social competence training also including conflict management skills founded by Lions Internal. Another evidence-based program providing social skills trainings for pre-school to middle school students is Second Step (http://www.secondstep.org/). Chaux and colleagues (2017[19]) defined a list of social and emotional competencies that children needed to acquire

towards conflict resolution, which were implemented in the *Aulas en Paz* (Classrooms in Peace) programme in Colombia; these include empathy, anger management, assertiveness, active listening, perspective-taking, creative generation of options, consideration of consequences and critical thinking. The programme reported reduction in teacher-reported aggression and increase in prosocial behaviours among students.

In their review of school-based conflict resolution education, Jones (2004[5]) found that most conflict resolution education programs yield positive outcomes by reducing violence and aggressive behaviours, reducing bullying and strengthening of social and emotional competencies such as empathy, perspective taking, and emotional awareness. While peer mediation programs are the most common kind of conflict resolution programs implemented in schools, Jones (2004[5]) articulated the need and merit of organizing whole school efforts as sustained initiatives in resolving conflicts and in developing lasting skills among students.

Measurability

In this section, we include measures that are established and have demonstrated good psychometric properties, such as reliability and validity. More research is needed on the measures and there is a need to move beyond self-reports to other forms of assessments such as teacher-report measures.

Table 1. List of instruments that measure conflict resolution skills or associated concepts

Instrument	Type	What does it measure?	What age/grade?	Context	References
Interpersonal Competence Questionnaire (ICQ)	Self-report	Interpersonal skills	Adults	*U.S.A and Germany*	(Buhrmester et al., 1988[51])
Conflict Resolution Style Inventory (CRSI)	Self-report	Conflict resolution styles	Students	*The Netherlands*	(De Weid, Branje and Meeus, 2007[52])
Can we teach children to be social? -Points of view for development of sociality of children and development of social problem solving in children at elementary school.	Self-report on hypothetical question	Problem solving skill when they face a trouble (e.g, what do you do in a football game when your teammate fails to kick the ball well and get the score?)	Grade 4 and 5	*Japan*	(Nagasaki, 2015[53])

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